THE POWER OF NAMING

by

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VICE PRESIDENT DAHLIN, DEAN CARLSON, FORMER HARRINGTON lecturers, Special Events Committee, students, colleagues, family, friends, ladies and gentlemen, you honor me, and you honor my department, with your presence.

I would like to talk tonight about some of the things I have learned about naming in the last few years and point out some examples of the power of naming. By "pointing out" I hope not to follow the example of Mrs. Kennedy during a television tour of the redecorated White House. When the reporter, looking toward the wall, asked her, "Would you point out some of the pictures to us?" Jackie replied, "Certainly. There's a picture, and there's a picture, and there's another picture over there" (Ashley 199).

One of the powers of naming is to evoke the past. When I look over the list of names of previous Harrington lecturers, I realize that, of the forty-six professors listed in the program, I am privileged to have been personally acquainted with forty-one. This certainly speaks to the collegiality of the College of Arts and Sciences and to the support and encouragement that these seasoned scholars gave to young people such as I once was. The names of those who have gone before evoke the traditions of this institution, not only in the list of lecturers but in the way that many of these names have become woven into the name texture of this University. I think of Beede Hall, of the Churchill Biology Building, of the Warren M. Lee Fine Arts Building, of the recently named Wayne S. Knutson Theatre, and most of all of this very auditorium, Farber Hall, whose namesake, William O. Farber, is with us in spirit tonight, though previous commitments prevented him from being here in person.

I think of other names from here and other places, three of whom I will mention. First, Edward C. Ehrensperger, professor of English from 1932 until his retirement in 1964 and chair of the department for thirty years, the record holder to date. Dr. Ehrensperger, who died in 1984 at the age of eighty-eight, had many intellectual passions, but the one that he kept coming back to was the study of names. He had edited the South Dakota placename study published by the WPA in 1941 and had directed sixteen M A. theses on the placenames of counties in the state. Toward the end of his life, when he realized that his

health and energy would not allow him to complete the vast amount of work still left to be done, he asked me to take over his work.

The second name is Claude Henry Neuffer, professor of English at the University of South Carolina. When I was in graduate school in Tennessee, I heard of an annual journal of placename studies of South Carolina, my home state, edited by Professor Neuffer. At about the same time, I ran across an 1896 book called *The Rhyme of the Southern Rivers,* a collection of doggerel verse incorporating the names of the rivers of the American South, by a certain Martin Van Buren Moore. The verses were less interesting than the etymological notes, in which Moore with great confidence and ingenuity but with little knowledge derived the names of all of the rivers in America from the names of the four rivers that, according to Genesis 2.10-14, flow out of the Garden of Eden. With the support of Professor Neuffer, I published in his journal an article explaining why Moore's etymologies are not at all reasonable. Professor Neuffer's illness and death in 1984 brought an end to the journal, but my connection to his work remains. In collaboration with his son, I am beginning to assemble a collection of the best of the articles that appeared in the journal about South Carolina names.

The third name I wish to mention is Allen Walker Read, who at ninety-four is still living in New York, where for many years he was professor of English at Columbia University. Read is one of the great scholars of the English language in America, known for his diligent research in obscure records. A profile in *The New Yorker* a few years ago (Stacey) highlights the best known of his scholarly detective work, his discovery of the origin of that universal expression *OK,* which he proved to be based on a waggish misspelling of *all correct* ("oll korrect") and then popularized as a motto in the 1840 presidential election of "Old Kinderhook," the nickname of Martin Van Buren. Read is also credited with demonstrating that the word *blizzard* in the sense we now know it originated in 1870 with a newspaper editor in Estherville, Iowa. Allen Walker Read was always open to anyone who sought inspiration and help in language and name study, but he took a special interest in me not only because of my connection to Ed Ehrensperger but also because he was originally from Iowa, had gone to what is now the University of Northern Iowa, and had been a classmate and friend

of Elbert Harrington, whose name we honor with this lecture tonight.

Dean Harrington conceived these lectures as a way for those in one discipline to share their ideas with those in other disciplines and thereby to encourage the concept of liberal education. In his 1972 book, *Janus on the Campus*, he attempted to define what a liberal education should be. Although much of what he says was already out of date in 1972, his brief definition is still valid: "Liberal education [...] is a preparation for making a life" and not just a preparation for making a living; its purpose is "the growth of the individual, the unfolding of the many sides of [the student's] personality" (22). He worried about the increasingly vocational orientations of university majors, as many of us still do, and he believed that any study that encourages students to become aware of a wider world and more sensitive to its diversity contributes to a liberal education. I like to think that the study of names, which crosses more disciplinary lines than any other field that I know of, makes such a contribution.

Several times in the last two decades I have offered a class in name study. One of the students from my 1996 class, Jeff Navin, a law student who works in Senator Daschle's office, recently wrote me about the class, in which he had the opportunity to study the geographic names of South Dakota. Learning the names and why they were given, he wrote,

> I was given a sense of what was important to those people—and a glimpse at who they were. The simplest names spoke to a pragmatic honesty (Mud Creek, Watertown, Sioux Falls), with a few surprisingly unique names thrown in the mix representing a bit of a sense of humor (Java, Tea—because Java was taken), or a reference to a poem (Rowena, Pukwana). And, of course, there is a sense of immortality attached to naming the creek or lake on your land after yourself.
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> I had always thought of place names as a political, or a legal concept. Vermillion, for example, is a political subdivision of Clay County, a political subdivision of South Dakota. But in looking back on it, [I realize that] the idea of a name is more of a human concept—we use names to provide a practical frame of reference, to honor those we look up to, to give

ourselves a sense of immortality, or to pass on a part of our collective selves. But most importantly, a name says "this is important"—it says that this is not just a hill, this is Spirit Mound. This *is not* a *few* buildings on the side of the road, this is Kranzburg—and we do take pride, but not too much pride, in South Dakota, in who we are, and where we arc.

In short, a name is representative of the values and characteristics of those who granted the name. And figuring out who we are is central to a liberal education.

The word for the study of names is *onomastics,* and those of us who practice it are called *onomasts.* Some people have told me that the word *onomastics* sounds just a little bit naughty, but it isn't, or at least it shouldn't be, although some of the ways that names can be used may be bad. Onomasts face several basic questions. First, what *is* a name? Second, where do names come from and who has the right to give them? Third, do names have meaning? And fourth, what effect do names have on those who use them and bear them?

The first question, What, is a name? is not as simple as it seems, and philosophers from Plato to Bertrand Russell have attempted to answer it. One of the earliest analytical discussions of naming is Plato's "Cratylus," which questions the relationship of a name to the thing named. In Plato's dialogue, Socrates moderates an argument between two friends: Cratylus insists that a name is inherently appropriate to the thing named, and Hermogenes believes that names are purely conventional. Cratylus claims that, in some distant past, legislators who understood the true nature of things gave names that accurately reflect reality, and any name in existence in the present that does not accurately represent the thing named has suffered from language corruption. Hermogenes, on the other hand, argues that names are but puffs of air and that one name is as good as another. While the arguments on both sides often seem exaggerated, the conclusion seems to suggest that there is some truth to both sides, and the question of whether the nature of a thing is comprehended in its name was de-

bated for centuries. To most of us, who tend to believe that names are purely conventional, the whole debate seems ridiculous, but for much of the history of Western thought a position close to that of Cratylus was held, and to a great extent it is central to the thinking of most other cultures of the world.

Many so-called primitive cultures treat names as an essential part of the bearer's identity, as much a part of the self as hair, nails, and other parts of the body. To reveal one's name to a stranger is to risk having that stranger use magic against one through the name (Frazer 235-46). You will remember, for example, the scene in Homer's *Odyssey* when Odysseus, captured by Polyphemos, the giant Cyclops, tells Polyphemos that his name is "Nobody." Odysseus and his men get the giant drunk and with a sharp stick poke out his one central eye. Polyphemos screams in pain and the other Cyclopes run to his cave and ask him who is killing him. Polyphemos screams back, "Nobody is killing me" (Lattimore 147 [9.408]). Then the others tell him to quit complaining, and they return to their own caves. Eventually Odysseus and his men get away from the blinded Cyclops. Another familiar example is the Grimm brothers' tale of Rumpelstiltskin, who claims the queen's first-born child unless she can guess his name, which she does. And Puccini's last opera, *Turandot,* turns on the premise that the hero, after answering the icy Princess Turandot's riddles, will release her from her obligation to marry him if she can guess his name. She doesn't, but it's okay, because she finally falls in love with him. The hero's name, by the way, is *Calaf* (Cross 609-18).

Even more powerful were the names of divine beings. In Egyptian mythology, in the early years of the world, the gods would not even reveal their names to each other. Ra, the sun god, was especially protective of his name, and like other gods he had so many that he could use a new one every day. Isis, as the story goes, was jealous of his power and knew that she could gain some of that power if she could learn his real name. Ra was a rather elderly god by this time, and one day Isis noticed that he was inclined to drool, so she gathered up a bit of his spittle from the ground and shaped it into a serpent, which then bit Ra. He suffered such great pain that he neglected to perform his duty to light the earth, and "the earth was plunged into darkness, shards of pottery began walking about, stones began to talk, and mountains

took to wandering hither and thither." Ra begged the other gods to help relieve the pain. Isis promised to help if he would reveal his true name, and he finally agreed (Meeks and Favard-Meeks 98)

The Old Testament stresses the unknowability of the true name of God. When Moses asks God to reveal his name so that he can tell it to the Children of Israel, he receives an off-putting answer: "I AM THAT I AM [....] Thus thou shalt say unto the children of Israel, I AM hath sent me unto thee" (Genesis 3.14). Kaplan and Bernays say that this dismissive answer is like saying "Never you mind who I am!" or even "Mind your own business!" On one level this refusal to be named means that God is too great to be confined in a name that ordinary people could know; on another it is the same "primitive" belief that to know the name of the god opens up the possibility of stealing his power (Kaplan and Bernays 16-17).

The idea that a name is an essential part of one's being plays an important role in our literary tradition. One example is in Shakespeare's *Romeo and Juliet, in* what may be the best-known passage in all of literature. In the first act of the play, Juliet, of the Capulet family, having fallen in love with Romeo, of the hated Montagues, asks rhetorically why he has to be a Montague:

> O Romeo, Romeo! Wherefore art thou Romeo?
> Deny thy father, and refuse thy name. (2.2.33-34)

And a bit later she asks that famous question (and note that she has not made the distinction between proper name and common noun):

> What's in a name? That which we call a rose
> By any other name would smell as sweet. (2.2.43-44)

Juliet is challenging that old assumption that a name is inherent in the thing that it names.

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The second question has two parts, Where do names come from and who has the right to give them? The question seems simple: names can be given by anyone who has command of a language; but the relationship among name, namer, and named is a complicated one involving privilege, ownership, and freedom.

We may get some insight from a passage from American travel writer Paul Theroux's 1983 book called *The Kingdom by the Sea,* a narrative of his travels by rail around the perimeter of Great. Britain. On the train leaving London, he takes a seat next to an Englishman, and in his carriage he observes an elderly couple, a little girl drinking a soft drink known as a Tizer, and a man reading the London *Daily Express.* Since on this trip he intends to avoid the usual tourist spots, he is annoyed when the man next to him tells him he should go to Canterbury. "They always said that, the natives," says Theroux. "They sent you to traipse around the sights—the ruins, the churches, the hot streets—and they went to a simple lovely place and had a beer under a tree" (9). Theroux then says,

> I guessed that his name was Norman Mould. It was one of my small talents to be able to tell a person's name by looking at him. Those old people up front—they were the Touchmores. The little girl drinking the Tizer—Judith Memery. The man behind the *Express*—Roger Cockpole. And so forth. (9)

Theroux is joking, of course. While it usually easy to determine a stranger's gender and perhaps possible to determine his or her nationality, it is totally illogical and I would say presumptuous to think we can "tell a person's name by looking at him." Theroux is playing a sort of literary game, for the fiction writer has the prerogative to choose names, but his presumptuousness takes us back to those old questions of the origin of names and the right to hand them out.

In the Old Testament, naming is the very first human action. In the second chapter of Genesis, just after the description of the Garden of Eden (and of the four rivers that flow out of it) and before Eve is cloned from Adam's rib, the narrator tells us that God created animals and birds "and brought them unto Adam to see what he would call them: and whatsoever Adam called every living creature, that was the name thereof. And Adam gave names to all cattle, and to the fowl of the air" (Genesis 2.19-20).

George R. Stewart, in a paper delivered at an academic conference, observed that naming was Adam's "first recorded activity," or at least his first intellectual action. "Before he composed a poem, or wrote

a scholarly article, or held a committee meeting," Stewart says, "Adam gave names" (1).

Just how did Adam know what to call all these animals? Genesis doesn't say, but John Milton (the one who wrote *Paradise Lost)* suggested that the knowledge was fed directly into Adam's consciousness by God. Book 8 of *Paradise Lost* recounts how God had given the earth and all its creatures to Adam and his descendants and how God had brought the creatures before Adam to be named. Then Adam tells how in naming them he also intuitively understood their true natures. The beasts and the birds came two by two, bowing low or dipping wings as a sign of respect, and Adam "named them as they passed, and understood / Their nature" through a power that God had mysteriously passed on to him (PL 8.351-54). The understanding that comes with naming, or, conversely, the naming which grows out of understanding, reflects Cratylus' view in Plato's dialogue.

The poet-painter William Blake seems also to have understood that Adam's naming was divinely inspired. A painting bearing the title *Adam Naming the Beasts* differs greatly from the one that I chose for the front of the program for this lecture. In Blake's picture, Adam, naked we assume but shown from just above where his navel (if he had one) would be, occupies most of the frame, with a few animals in the background. Adam stares straight ahead with large almond eyes while stroking the head of a serpent which is coiled about his left arm. The index finger of his right hand is directed toward the sky, as if drawing down wisdom. His mouth is closed, as if the naming is an act of knowing rather than an act of speaking (Essick 8, plate 1).

Mark Twain had a good bit of fun with this whole idea of naming in Eden. In a satirical piece called "Extracts from the Diaries of Adam and Eve," Twain imagines Adam's confusion over the appearance of the new creature with the long hair who is "always hanging around and following me about," meaning Eve, of course. His entry for Tuesday says,

> Been examining the great waterfall. It is the finest thing on the estate, I think. The new creature calls it Niagara Falls—why, I am sure I do not know. Says it *looks* like Niagara Falls. That is not a reason, it is mere waywardness and imbecility. I get no chance

> to name anything myself. The new creature names everything that comes along, before I can get in a protest. And always that same pretext is offered—it *looks* like the thing. There is the dodo, for instance. Says the moment one looks at it one sees at a glance that, it "looks like a dodo." It will have to keep that name, no doubt. It wearies me to fret about it, and it does no good, anyway. Dodo! It looks no more like a dodo than I do. (55)

In his paper on Adam's naming, George Stewart goes on to discuss the way that placenames are given in our early traditions. In Greek antiquity, the idea that a feature was nameless did not occur. In an ancient book called the pseudo-Plutarch because it was once thought that that famous biographer was the author, whenever a geographical feature is mentioned by name, such as a river, he narrates an incident, usually a violent drowning, and the name of the drowning person has become the name of the river. "The Greek assumption," he says, "seems to have been that a place always had a name. You learned what the name was, and used it" (3). Stewart credits this onomastic humbleness with Greek enlightened tolerance and contrasts it with the conquest of America, especially by the Spanish in their conquest of the Aztecs, Incas, and other natives. The Spaniard "had no qualms about displacing their names, and [. . .] substituting those of his own religion—such as names of the saints, or Santa Fe, or Trinidad. And the other Europeans did very much the same" (5). In the Greek tradition, to give another example, Odysseus, who can rename himself with no hesitation, comes to many a strange land, "but never once does he think he needs to name it." This is in contrast with, for instance, the attitude in the Norse sagas about the discovery of America, in which the first act of the hero in sighting a hitherto unknown land is to give it a name (4), the best known being *Vinland.*

The naming of places in the Northern Plains, our part of the world, follows the pattern of that of much of the rest of the Western Hemisphere. To their credit, many of the early explorers made the effort, like the Greeks, to find out the names of features and used those names when they wrote accounts or drew maps of their findings. Lewis and Clark, for all their great discoveries, did not add as many names to the

map of the West as one would expect, especially up to the 1804-05 winter camp at Fort Mandan. When Sergeant Floyd died near where Sioux City is today, Clark notes that the river which they named in his honor and which still bears his name was a "Small river *without a name* [my italics]" on the maps they were carrying (Moulton 2:495). A later explorer, Joseph Nicollet, who produced in 1843 a map of this region, took great pains to learn the Dakota language and to learn from the Indians he met what names they used (Bray and Bray 251). He placed these names on his great map, but in later times surveyors and explorers changed most of them when Dakota Territory came into being. Consequently, in eastern South Dakota the number of both natural features and settlements that have names of Indian origin is surprisingly small when we consider the long association Indians had with the region. The main reason, I think, is that most of eastern South Dakota was settled during the time that the war against the Sioux was at its peak, and generally people avoid naming features for the enemy. Many of the names which *are* of Indian origin come not from local Indian presence but from distant eastern Indians *(Huron, Iroquois, Onida,* and *Osceola)* or from romanticized literature, especially Longfellow's *Hiawatha (Pukwana* and *Minnehaha).* Most of the other names in this state, especially of counties and towns, honor the values and prejudices of the settlers of the nineteenth century.

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The third question is, Do names have meaning? One aspect of this question is, what is the difference between a name and a word, or, in grammatical terms, between a proper noun and a common noun? Linguist Frederick G. Cassidy says it succinctly: "Names confer particular being or individual identity while words refer generally" (262). Because the general reference defines a category of similar things, the common noun loses its ability to refer to things as individuals, while a proper noun, or name, points, as it were, to a specific example drawn from experience, the only way we can know a name. Bertrand Russell, perhaps with a touch of irony, goes so far as to suggest that, since a name points to one thing only, the only logically proper names are *this* and *that* (Russell 179; Zabeeh 19).

Cassidy claims that when children first learn language, everything is a name. "For a child first grasping the system, there are only names, *bed, finger, doll:* there is only one of each in his experience. The move from name to word comes with the discovery that there are other similar things. The child may cling to the original, familiar object: *my* bed, *my* finger, *my* doll, or may discover the general naming process and name the doll *Dolly"* (262).

Another way to understand the distinction between words and names is to visualize all nouns in separate columns. Every language has its own vocabulary, a virtual treasury of thousands of words that a speaker of that language begins to learn at a very early age and with some effort continues to add to for the rest of her or his life. When we use a word we acknowledge a social contract that the word has meaning to other speakers in our speech community, which is why the famous lines that Lewis Carroll in *Through the Looking Glass* gives to Humpty Dumpty strike us as funny. "When I use a word," Humpty Dumpty says to Alice, "it means just what I choose it to mean—neither more nor less" (Carroll 269).

The collective vocabulary of a language is its *lexicon,* the words that, according to this social contract, belong to that language. This is the list in the column on the left. In the other column is a list of the *names* in a language that the members of a society find acceptable. Some onomasts use the term *onomasticon* for this imaginary list. At a simple level the distinction between the two is that the sounds that belong in our lexicon have meaning, while the sounds in our onomasticon have reference. We don't require names to have meaning, despite the insistence of Humpty Dumpty, who demands of Alice what her name means. "Must a name mean something," she asks "Of course it must," he replies (Carroll 263).

Since many, perhaps most, names come from words in the lexicon, it could be argued that they have meaning. If your name is *Smith* perhaps one of your ancestors worked in metal, but few of the millions of people named Smith work in metal anymore, and neither they nor the people who address them are likely to think that the sound *smith* has a lexical meaning. Similarly, if a girl tells you her name is *Rose,* no matter how sweet she is, you would probably not visualize the flower. But

sometimes the line between lexicon and onomasticon is crossed in a way that makes us laugh. There are many people who collect humorous names of this sort, especially from the American South, but I will spare you all but a few.

One collector found, for example, girls named *Lasagna, Famous, Fourteen, Glorious,* and *Nylon* (Lorenz 216). As *lexical* items, these are in no way amusing, but when they cross over into the onomasticon they are funny, and also unfortunate. One of the best linguists of a previous generation, Thomas Pyles (whose own name was the butt of many jokes), published an article a few decades back with the title, "Bible Belt Onomastics or some Curiosities of Anti-Pedobaptist Nomenclature," which has become a minor classic in the field. Pyles' premise is that in the South, which has a strong tradition of adult baptism, live many people who were named without benefit of clergy, and he cites such names as *Buzz Buzz, Coeta, Merdine, Aslean, La Void, Arsie, Phalla,* and *Raz,* all legal names of "Bible Belters of repute." "And it is certain," he adds, "that Ima Hogg, the *grande dame* of Houston society, whose father was once governor of Texas, was so named without the connivance of any anointed priest" (Pyles 86-87). Miss Hogg, by the way, was real enough, but her alleged sister *Yura Hogg* and brother *Hesa Hogg* are purely the creation of folklore—or of the governor's political enemies (Rennick 193-95).

It is tempting to think that the connection between our names and who we are is more than incidental. The word for names that are appropriate for one's profession or personality is aptronym (or aptonym). Paul Dickson has a sizable collection, which he assures us are real people. A few examples from the professions: J. H. Argue, attorney; *Louis Chase,* Oklahoma highway patrolman; *Dan Druff,* barber; *James God,* Baptist minister; and C. *Sharpe Minor,* organist. People who must have changed their residences just for the fun of it include *Penny Nichols* from *Money,* Mississippi, and *L Q. Sharpe* of *Braintree,* Massachusetts. And you have probably heard of all of these: *Rollie Fingers,* major league pitcher; *Gary Player,* professional golfer; and *Larry Speakes,* President Reagan's press secretary (Dickson 26-32). Were these people in some mysterious way guided by the lexical content of their names? We may wonder if someone with a cheerful name like *Smiley,* for instance, is likely to

grow up to be cheerful, and, conversely, if someone would grow up to be contrary because his name happened to be Converse.

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Serious studies support the idea that names may affect how people react to first names they perceive to be desirable, and this brings me to my fourth and final question, What effect do names have on those who bear them and those who use them? One study in an elementary school, for example, concluded that teachers showed favoritism by giving higher grades to boys with names like *Craig, Gregory, Richard,* and *Thomas,* and lower grades to *Curtis, Daryl, Arnold, Horace,* and *Samuel* (Dickson 176; Garwood et al. 319). In another study college students were shown pictures of beauty queens tagged with first names that another study had determined to be positive or negative. The same pictures rated higher on the beauty scale when positive names were attached (Garwood et al. 319-20). The stereotypes go both ways. A 1984 poll found that first graders would rather have a substitute teacher named *Stephanie* than one named Bertha; Bertha would make them work harder (Dickson 175). Such studies suggest that names stereotype as much as skin color and other surface characteristics, but the results would probably shift as different names became popular.

Names seem to be so much a part of the fabric of the person or the place bearing the name that it is tempting to give credence to Cratylus' view that names are natural. But name study reveals that names almost always have been arbitrarily and even casually assigned. Many people also assume that names have legal standing and cannot be changed without a court order, but courts have consistently ruled that one can choose almost any sound for a name, so long as there is no attempt to defraud. There have been some exceptions. In a famous case in the 1970s, a North Dakota man named Michael Herbert Dengler decided to change his name to 1069, which he wrote with digits, *1-0-*6-9. He claimed that this "name" represented his relationship to nature, time, the universe, and essence. The case went all the way to the U. S. Supreme Court, which refused to hear it, but the state courts

(Mr. 1069 later moved to Minnesota) refused to let him change his name legally, but did not prohibit him from *using* it. The *courts offered* to let him write his name as words-One *Zero Six* Nine-but he refused (Lockney and Ames). So far as I know, Mr. 1069 still uses that name. Perhaps it was the precedent for the musician Prince, who changed his name to a symbol that cannot be pronounced at all.

In this country, there are no legal restrictions on what to name a child as there are in some other countries. In Norway, for instance, first names must come from a list approved by a government agency. France also has a list, but in recognition *of its* growing ethnic diversity, allows a name not on the list if parents can document its use within their culture. In America, we assume the right—the power—to name our children anything we want to; there are no legal prohibitions, and it *is* the groups traditionally with less power, such as African-Americans, who have exercised that power to its fullest extent.

It was customary for a long time in our Western society to restrict the power of a woman to control her own naming destiny, when she was compelled to take the name *of* her husband at marriage. Some scholars date the beginning of the end of this custom to 1856, when a Massachusetts woman named Lucy Stone, who had married Henry Blackwell a year earlier and had become Mrs. Henry Blackwell, decided to *go* back to her original name. Although it was tradition and not actual laws that prohibited this, anytime she signed a legal document, she was required to add "wife of Henry Blackwell" to her birth-name signature. This went on for years. When in 1879 it became legal for women in Massachusetts to vote for members *of* the school committee, she signed the register under the name Lucy Stone, and the Board of Registrars disallowed it. Lucy Stone was famous in her day, and generally considered a threat to morality and the American way, but her influence led to the creation in 1918 of The Lucy Stone League, devoted to the right of women to determine their own identities (Stannard 114-18).

In our time, when it has become almost the norm for women, especially in professional positions, to keep their own names, Lucy Stones struggle seems quaint. But the custom of requiring the use of the husband's name sent a very strong message to women. The tradition identifying a woman by prefacing her husband's name with Mrs., says

Claire Culleton, gives her a name which

> has only one marker that distinguishes it from her husband's name, one marker that indicates that she is *not* her husband [. . .]. Any name acquired through marriage, then, identifies the woman in terms of what she is not. Linguistically and semantically, the title Mrs. acts as a marker to identify what is *not* there: since the title Mrs. has always declared gender, when placed before the name of the husband, Mrs. declares the absence of the phallus since it feminizes the name that *follows.* The wife becomes, by name, an inferiorized version of her husband, a Mrs. Him. She shares his identical name, but she is forever diminished because the name is not her own. Thus, the married woman metamorphoses into a forgery of the husband. (73)

I don't mean to say, of course, that women *should* keep their birth names when they marry; that would also deprive them of a basic right. The women's movement has empowered women to make their own choices. Self-naming is one of the most important symbolic and actual dimensions of that empowerment.

If we turn once again to placenames, we can see that those who hold political power have often wielded that power through names. Most familiar are instances in the Soviet world where the names of cities were changed to honor Revolutionary leaders and not incidentally to remind the citizens of where the authority came from. In Russia *St. Petersburg* (itself a power game by Peter the Great who claimed to be honoring his namesake) became *Leningrad,* and *Chemnitz* in East Germany became *Karl-Marx-Stadt.* When the Soviet Union crumbled, these cities quickly resumed their previous names. Closer to home, town names such as *Mitchell* and *Aberdeen* reminded those who settled there of what they owed to the Milwaukee Railroad and its president Alexander Mitchell, a native of Aberdeen, Scotland. And farther west, the names *Philip* and Murdo alerted passersby that cattle barons Scotty Philip and Murdo McKenzie controlled this land.

What we call people and what we call places reveal the ways that we feel about ourselves and how we relate to other people and our environment. These feelings intensify when the names apply to those

parts of our lives in which we have the greatest emotional involvement. In the last few years, one of these parts has been the names of athletic teams. Perhaps it's not the name itself but the attitude behind it that is bad, leading to offensive logos and mascots. The name Braves makes an obvious reference to Native American warriors, and the Atlanta team claims to be honoring Indians. But the fans, with the full support of owner Ted Turner and the media, insult the Indians with the stereotyped war chant and "tomahawk chop." (With role models like this, is it any wonder that John Rocker saw nothing wrong with making racist remarks?) The Cleveland Indians have for years fostered bigotry with their mascot, "Chief Wahoo," a cartoon Indian with exaggerated Indian features. Protests, including burning a straw effigy of the figure in 1997, led to arrests of activists; when there was another protest last spring, fans wearing the logo on jackets and sweatshirts booed the Native Americans who were protesting ("Protestors" 1C). For many years the Native American community nationwide has protested this action. Of the professional team names, none is more offensive than the Washington *Redskins,* but the owners refuse to consider changing. We're not ridiculing, we're honoring Indian traditions, they say, while fans paint their faces, wear stereotyped costumes, and in general make fun of Indians.

Even universities ridicule Native Americans. The University of Illinois, by all accounts an enlightened place of liberal arts and learning, its teams calling themselves the *Mini,* "honor" the tradition with "Chief Illiniwek," another cartoon figure cavorting around the field to the cheers of the crowd. Last year protestors were abused and had bottles thrown at them. At the University of North Dakota, Indian students have been lobbying since 1970 to drop the name *Fighting Sioux.* Both the faculty senate in 1993 and the student senate in 1999 passed resolutions to change the name, but the alumni, the athletic department, and the administration have not been in favor.

I learned much about this issue last spring when I attended a conference in Brookings called "What's in a Name," the focus of which was derogatory names of athletic teams. The keynote speaker was Barbara Munson from the Oneida Nation of Wisconsin, who has led a movement to bring about the elimination of nicknames, logos, and

mascots that are offensive to Indian people. Many non-Indians are unaware that such nicknames as *Indians, Warriors,* Brakes, and *Redskins* are offensive, and others don't seem to care. Some claim to be honoring Indians by representing them as fierce warriors and competitors. To this absurdity, most Indians say they don't feel honored; they feel hurt. In the words of Barbara Munson, "When someone says you are hurting them by your action, if you persist then the harm becomes intentional" (5).

To their credit, many schools have changed their names or at least their logos: Morningside College changed its team name from the *Chiefs* to the *Mustangs.* Yankton High School teams are still the *Bucks,* but their logo is now a male deer rather than a male Indian. Recent Associated Press stories report that the new president of the University of North Dakota has appointed a commission to study discarding the school's nickname, *Fighting Sioux.* As of a year ago, the latest information I have, some six hundred teams at all levels have dropped their Indian mascots, but some 2,500 have not (Giago 13C).

Names do indeed have meaning. Even if they don't have meaning in the denotative sense like a word in the lexicon, they have meaning in the connotative, emotional sense. Name-calling does not, like a stick or a stone, hurt our bodies, but it hurts us in other ways; names can define, offend, control, and possess. But names can also honor and evoke the memory of those who have shaped our lives in the past and will do so in the future. It is interesting to speculate on which of you here tonight may one day have a space on this campus named in your honor, either because you will have contributed to the great liberating mission of education through your teaching, your scholarship, or your service, as did Grace Beede, Bill Farber, or Wayne Knutson; or you will have contributed your money, as did those whose names appear on the rooms of this building or on the chairs you have already sat in too long tonight. There is great power in naming.

Thank you for listening.

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